economies are hit harder, so we must coordinate. With your leadership, I have no doubt we will see immediate and impactful outcome. Looking forward to the video conference.'[7]

Nepali Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli replied, 'I welcome the idea advanced by Prime Minister Modiji @narendramodi for chalking out a strong strategy by the leadership of the SAARC nations to fight Coronavirus. My government is ready to work closely with SAARC Member States to protect our citizens from this deadly disease.'[8]

The President of Maldives Ibrahim Mohamed Solih showed his support as well, 'Thank you PM @narendramodi for taking the initiative on this important endeavor. COVID 19 requires collective effort to defeat it. Maldives welcomes this proposal and would fully support such a regional effort.'[9]

Bangladeshi Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, too, showed her readiness and enthusiasm to engage as per a tweet by Bangladesh's Minister of State for Foreign Affairs. Adding to the list, the Afghan envoy in New Delhi Tahir Qadiry also acknowledged PM Modi's call. Pakistan, too, conveyed via diplomatic channels that its Special Assistant to the Prime Minister would join the video conference.

On 15 March, the video conference of SAARC leaders on combatting COVID-19 was held. In his opening remarks, the prime minister advocated for collaboration over confusion and preparation over panic.[10] He pointed out that SAARC nations face similar challenges in terms of dense population, our interconnected societies and access to healthcare. He informed the leaders on various proactive steps that India has been taking such as upgrading our response mechanism, screenings at airports, gradual increase in travel restrictions, increasing public-awareness campaigns on television, print and social media, efforts to quickly ramp up our healthcare system, including training of healthcare staff, increasing diagnostic capacities (going from one to 66 in two months), developing protocols for managing each stage of the pandemic, contact tracing of suspected cases, management of quarantine and isolation facilities, evacuating over 1,400 Indians and citizens of neighbourhood nations from different countries and building protocol for such evacuations including carrying out testing by deployed mobile teams.[11]